

Prioritizing organizational success and the pursuit of victory: Understanding the feelings of exclusion in the workplace

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates how an organizational bottom-line mentality (BLM) climate influences employee perceptions of workplace ostracism, with a focus on the moderating role of zero-sum beliefs (ZSB). Using a survey of 220 full-time respondents in the United States, we conducted regression analysis and moderated mediation tests via Hayes' PROCESS macro in R. We measured perceived organizational BLM, employee BLM, ZSB, and work ostracism using validated scales. The results supported all five hypotheses. An organizational BLM climate positively influences employee BLM, which in turn increases perceptions of ostracism. This relationship is stronger for employees with high ZSB. Additionally, the indirect effect of an organizational BLM climate on ostracism through employee BLM is significantly moderated by ZSB. The findings highlight that employees with high ZSB experience greater ostracism in high-BLM environments. Drawing on Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) this study investigates and underscores the negative interpersonal outcomes of a BLM climate. By addressing zero-sum beliefs through targeted interventions, organizations can balance financial objectives with employee well-being, enhancing workplace dynamics and morale.

1. Introduction

In today's performance-driven business climate, organizations often prioritize financial outcomes above relational and developmental values. While this focus can drive short-term gains and market competitiveness, it may also foster environments where employee well-being, inclusion, and collaborative culture are de-emphasized, leading to feelings of exclusion among individuals who do not directly contribute to measurable success (Carroll, 1991). This emphasis can promote what scholars term a bottom-line mentality (BLM) – a one-dimensional focus on financial performance to the exclusion of other concerns. In such environments, some employees may also demonstrate thinking as a zero-sum beliefs (ZSB) – thoughts that one person's gain is another's loss (Greenbaum et al., 2012). Importantly, research suggest that BLM climates can reduce psychological safety (Bonner, 2013), increase unethical behavior (Resick et al., 2023), heighten competition

(Xie et al., 2022), and contribute to insomnia (Babalola et al., 2022). Furthermore, due to the nature of BLM to involve cognition related to prioritization, Castille et al. (2018) identified a link from BLM to amoral manipulation, a desire for control, and distrust. While these findings highlight the consequences of BLM for employee well-being, its specific relationship with workplace ostracism remains understudied.

Workplace ostracism is defined as “the extent to which an individual perceives that they are ignored or excluded by others at work” (Ferris et al., 2008, p. 1348). Often conceptualized as a subtle yet harmful form of mistreatment, ostracism can undermine an employee's sense of belonging and psychological health (Ferris et al., 2017). In particular, worker ostracism is associated with psychological resource depletion, leading to emotional exhaustion, negligence, and knowledge hoarding behaviors (Asghar et al., 2025; Li et al., 2025). Importantly, brief episodes of social exclusion have also been shown to significantly increase emotional distress and negative self-perceptions, thus highlighting the

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importance of this psychological phenomenon (Chao & Jackson, 2023). Although past studies have suggested a link between competitive climates and exclusionary behaviors (Howard et al., 2020; Ng, 2017), the psychological mechanisms through which employees may come to feel ostracized in BLM environments are limited. This being so, there is emerging scholarly interest on this topic (see Keeler et al., in press). Their work used an experimental 2×2 AI video vignette to evaluate student perceptions of ostracism, while considering BLM and ZSB. Beyond this most recent study, much of the existing research has focused on supervisory BLM rather than climate based as an influence that leads to various negative outcomes (e.g., Bonner, 2013). We argue this is a gap, especially in understanding employee internalization, reasoning, or adoption of psychological changes in response to a given organizational climate. This raises the question: how and under what conditions might a BLM climate lead employees to feel ostracized, even in the absence of overt exclusion?

To address this question, Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) (Bandura, 1986, 1989, 2001) is drawn upon. It posits that individuals learn behaviors and interpret social norms by observing their environment and the actions of others. Within a BLM climate, employees may observe peers or supervisors prioritizing performance above collaboration or inclusion, leading them to internalize the belief that exclusionary behavior is acceptable, or even normative. This process of observational learning and norm adoption, central to SCT, may result in feelings of social disconnection for those who do not conform to the dominant climate. Thus, SCT offers a theoretical lens through which to examine how organizational values and prioritization become embedded in employee perceptions, likely to affect interpersonal dynamics.

Further, a case is made to distinguish between BLM and zero-sum beliefs (ZSB), concepts often conflated in existing literature (Babalola et al., 2020; Babalola et al., 2022; Greenbaum et al., 2023). While BLM describes an organizational climate, ZSB reflects an individual's belief or social axiom that success is limited and must come at someone else's expense (Andrews-Fearon & Davidai, 2023). We argue that ZSB functions as a key moderator, such that employees with high ZSB may be more likely to perceive exclusion in BLM settings due to heightened sensitivity to competitive cues.

This study offers several contributions to the literature concerning psychological processes related to organizational behavior and workplace ethics. First, we extend prior work on BLM by empirically linking it to employee ostracism, an underexamined social outcome of competitive climates (Babalola et al., 2020; Babalola et al., 2022; Crocker & Canevello, 2008; Howard et al., 2020; Keeler et al., in press; Xie et al., 2022). Second, we apply SCT to explain how environmental cues in a BLM context shape employee cognition and social interpretation, advancing the understanding of the mechanisms behind workplace exclusion. Third, we clarify the role of zero-sum beliefs as a boundary condition for BLM's impact, providing new insights into individual-level variability in workplace responses. By integrating climate-level and

individual-level perspectives, we offer a more nuanced model of how organizational priorities can affect social inclusion at work. These findings carry important implications for managers seeking to balance performance goals with employee well-being and inclusion.

2. Theoretical and hypothesis development

To understand the relatedness of variables in our model (see Fig. 1), we utilized Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) as proposed by Bandura (Bandura, 1986, 1989). Social Cognitive Theory highlights the mutual relationship between individuals and their organizational climate (Bandura, 1986), suggesting that individuals recognize other employee's behaviors, skills training, perceived social support, persuasion, and environmental context to play an important role in shaping them to behave in a certain way (Martin et al., 2014; Otaye-Ebede et al., 2020). It further argues that individuals learn by observing others in their environment and understanding expected norms regarding how to act and think in organizations (Bandura, 1986).

Based on research by Cherian and Jacob (2013), SCT's principles can be applied to understand perceptions of organizational climate on employees. As such, given the nature of a climate to be an environmental context in our study, we believe it makes sense for individuals to be influenced by not only their work behavior but potentially their mindsets, too. The interest in a particular work climate of this study is to examine how employees' perceived their organization's shared policies, practices and procedures relative to competitiveness and prioritization (Ostroff et al., 2003; Schneider, 1975). SCT can help understand both intra and interpersonal processes within business environments and how they shape employees' attitudes towards a mindset rooted in the bottom-line. This is important as individuals consistently regulate their behavior and personal factors (e.g., cognitions, beliefs, attitudes, mindsets) by comparing their standard of conduct in response to environmental circumstances, especially climates that encompasses ethics and decision making (Bandura, 1986; Domino et al., 2015). Similarly, work by Mittal et al. (2024) also found environmental factors such as incivility at home, or work environments that are focused on competition rather than collaboration, play an important role shaping individuals' psychological states and behaviors. Based on the tenets of SCT to entail behavior is learned via observation, modeling, internalization, and also reinforcement from environments (Bandura, 1986, 1989, 2001), theoretically, this is aligned for understanding the connected relationships we propose in this study. Our work makes an argument for a cognitive mindset adoption to take place when employees observe organizational artifacts and cues, thus prompting them to adapt to the climate they work within. Furthermore, based on reasons of compliance and conformity (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004) along with self-interest (Kouchaki et al., 2013; Mitchell et al., 2018), we feel the SCT is strengthened as an explanatory framework as to how a BLM-based organizational climate can influence a worker's mindset adoption and interpersonal social feelings

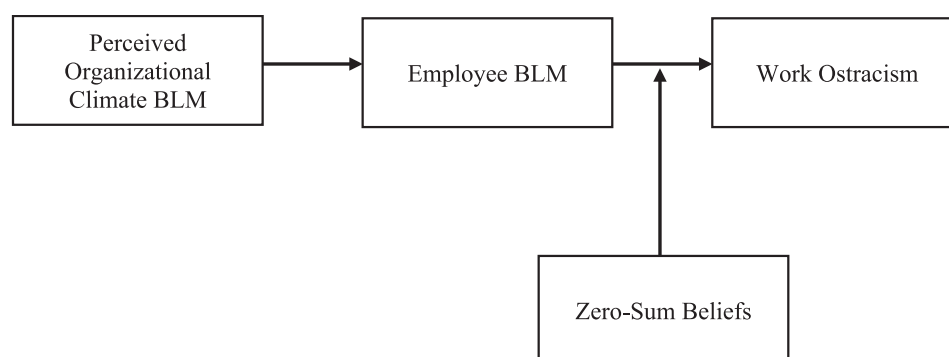


Fig. 1. Hypothesized theoretical model.
Source: Authors' own work.

concerning exclusion.

2.1. Perceived organizational BLM climate, employee BLM, and ostracism

Bottom-line mentality (BLM) is a concept operationalized as a one-track prioritization mindset that is concerned with specific immediate goals along the lines of “tunnel” vision. The mindset is such that competing or more important priorities are ignored because of a fixation on particular goals (Greenbaum et al., 2012). Specific to employee BLM, arguably, it is adopted by employees in organizations that emphasize a business-first climate. In the literature, the research streams often study how this mentality is influenced by supervisors with BLM, thus affecting the employee (Babalola et al., 2021; Farasat et al., 2021; Greenbaum et al., 2012; Zhang et al., 2020; Zhang et al., 2021). Understandably, employees observing their leaders' behaviors are likely to shape their perception of and identification with BLM (Bandura, 1977; Sims Jr & Manz, 1982). Further, Domino et al. (2015), in their study on corporate accountants, provide evidence that the greater the organizational climate fit, the more likely an individual is to conform to organizational norms.

Per the observational learning premise of SCT, such theory can offer valuable insights into how employees perceive and respond to a POCBLM (Chernyak-Hai & Davidai, 2022; Sims Jr & Manz, 1982). In essence, it is process of learning and adaptation, which is central to SCT (Bandura, 1986). As a result, employees are likely to internalize BLM initiatives. Employees most likely do this to fit in with the climate of the organization. Knowing that employees are observing and adjusting their actions consistently, an environment heavily focused on the bottom line may encourage employees to internalize similar values and priorities (Wingreen et al., 2009). As a result, the stronger the perceived organizational climate, the greater the possibility that employees will identify with a bottom-line mentality (BLM). Babalola et al. (2020) demonstrate that employees adopt a bottom-line focus when top management prioritizes financial outcomes, leading to both productive and counter-productive behaviors aligned with organizational goals.

Similarly, Hanu et al. (2024) find that owner-managers BLM in MSMEs significantly predict employees' proactive behavior and their adoption of a bottom-line mentality, emphasizing the direct influence of supervisors on employee work orientation. Farasat et al. (2021) further support this by showing that a supervisor's BLM fosters workaholism and workplace cheating, especially when employee entitlement is high, thus reinforcing the idea that a BLM climate encourages employees to internalize this mentality. Zhang et al. (2021) reveal that while supervisor BLM can improve work performance, it may also lead to knowledge hiding among subordinates, with gender playing a moderating role. Finally, Chen et al. (2022) show that a supervisor's BLM boosts employees' work effort and helps behavior by enhancing their commitment to bottom-line goals, particularly in collectivist environments. However, the dynamics of how POCBLM influences employees' BLM identification and the role of SCT in this process remain largely unexplored. This research, therefore, aims to bridge this gap by applying SCT to investigate the relationship between POCBLM and employee BLM.

Based on these arguments, we hypothesize the following:

Hypothesis 1. An organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality is positively related to an employee bottom-line mentality.

It is vital to see the changes in how Bottom-Line Mentality (BLM) was once only examined because it was originally the bottom number on an income statement. Prior to Greenbaum et al. (2012), BLM was solely related to financial results. Today, Bottom-Line Mentalities (BLMs) are no longer viewed as just financial gain; individuals with high BLMs are focused on their success, whether it be tied to organizational results, the business environment, achieving praise, or specific career goals (Greenbaum et al., 2012). BLMs among employees involve a focus on achieving personal success and bottom-line outcomes, often overshadowing other considerations (Eissa et al., 2020; Greenbaum et al.,

2012). According to Eissa et al. (2020), employees with high BLMs prioritize their success, often making decisions and acting in ways that align with this priority (Callahan, 2007; Wolfe, 1988). Individuals with high BLMs believe that the bottom line is the only important outcome that can lead to a competitive stance, seeing only winners and losers in the workplace. Individuals with high BLMs are more prone to ignore individuals in the workplace, which undermines their colleague's respect and places a strain on relationships, both social and interpersonal, in the workplace (Riisla et al., 2021).

Research by Riisla et al. (2021) provides evidence that leaders with high BLMs can influence an employee's approach to their work, emphasizing individual success and outcomes over team-oriented goals because of their preoccupation with achieving bottom-line results rather than fostering interpersonal relationships. Employees adopting this mentality, in order to align with the social expectations of the organization and their leader will then be less likely to seek out collaboration promoting a competitive rather than cooperative environment (Eissa et al., 2020). Further, employees adopting a higher BLM may have an overemphasis on business-first outcomes to the exclusion of other considerations. They might prioritize their success above all else and view organizational outcomes as a zero-sum game (Greenbaum et al., 2012; Riisla et al., 2021). While this individual mindset is in alignment with the organization, it nonetheless can lead employees to be “in it for themselves,” leading to perceptions of isolation and exclusion. This is an example of the self-interest component (Tenbrunsel & Messick, 1999). Research suggests that employees with a strong BLM might engage in behaviors that can lead to feelings of alienation and social undermining and experience intensified feelings of shame among their colleagues (Bonner et al., 2017; Greenbaum et al., 2012; Riisla et al., 2021). Thus, an organization with a high prevalence of BLMs might see increased feelings of ostracism or exclusion among its employees, even when employees also possess a high individual BLM.

Given the potential for a highly competitive, individualistic climate to develop feelings of isolation, and feelings of ostracism or exclusion for those that identify with the BLM climate it is reasonable to assume that those who do not align will both feel ostracized and more likely to be ostracized by others. Babalola et al. (2020) provide evidence that in work environments dominated by a BLM, employees who do not align with this mentality often report feelings of exclusion and marginalization. Liu et al. (2022) find that a strong BLM can result in a psychological contract breach when employees feel their contributions, particularly those related to innovation and long-term goals, are undervalued compared to immediate financial outcomes. This breach often leads to feelings of undervaluation and exclusion. Quade et al. (2022) further support this by demonstrating that a supervisor's BLM can foster a work environment where financial results are prioritized over interpersonal relationships, potentially causing employees with a strong BLM to feel isolated or ostracized. Complementing these findings, Greenbaum et al. (2012) reveal that BLM is positively associated with social undermining, a behavior that often results in employees being isolated or ostracized by their peers. Therefore, it seems that while a BLM may lead to individual success in terms of bottom-line outcomes, it could also lead to a divisive work environment, potentially fostering feelings of ostracism and exclusion among employees who do not adhere to or align with this mentality (Bonner et al., 2017; Greenbaum et al., 2012; Riisla et al., 2021). According to Singh et al. (2024), ostracized employees often experience distress, lower engagement, and increased turnover intentions. These attributes are likely to be exacerbated in BLM climates. Consequently, we hypothesize the following:

Hypothesis 2. Employee bottom-line mentality is positively related to felt ostracism by employees.

Hypothesis 3. An organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality has a positive indirect effect on felt ostracism via increased employee bottom-line mentality.

2.2. The moderating effects of generalized zero-sum belief thinking

When examining the relationship that organizational climate has on perceived bottom-line mentality, research provides evidence that individuals are constantly looking to their coworkers and superiors to gauge climate. In a BLM climate, this can be even more intense as the environment is one in which individuals will go to great measures to “win.”

Zero-sum belief or zero-sum situations are defined by Crocker and Canevello (2008) individuals' psychological construction of wins and losses. This construct is commonly described as a social axiom or deep-rooted belief system (Różycka-Tran et al., 2015). Such beliefs are not typically acquired from an organization or supervisor but rather culturally. From a SCT lens, such beliefs (a type of personal factor) are learned over a greater span of time. For instance, those with a high ZSB hold that there are finite resources and that there is only one winner and one loser. This construct aligns with the proposed hypotheses in that individuals believe there are a finite number of resources. Zero-sum beliefs can have important interpersonal and societal consequences in organizations. When individuals have a zero-sum belief, they place their own needs first and are not concerned with the needs of their coworkers. Individuals work to maximize their gains, and if they help others in the organization, it comes from a place of self-interest (Crocker & Canevello, 2015). Moreover, observing exclusion incidents can heighten individuals' fear of future rejection, which may be amplified among those with strong zero-sum beliefs (Yan et al., 2024). In general, the more employees view situations as a zero-sum belief, the more individual employees will try to stifle others' progress (Andrews-Fearon & Davidai, 2023; Wilkins et al., 2015). Ironically, zero-sum situations inversely link employee outcomes to each other, requiring them directly or indirectly harm other employees. Not surprisingly, zero-sum beliefs are associated with reduced trust among employees (Różycka-Tran et al., 2015), a general cynicism about society (Zaki et al., 2021), diminished well-being, increased prejudice, and a tendency to attribute hostile intention to other employees' behavior (Andrews-Fearon & Davidai, 2023; Chernyak-Hai & Davidai, 2022; Fearon et al., 2021).

Employees with high zero-sum belief systems, being that they believe there is only a certain number of available resources, will likely focus their cognitive energy in an over compensatory manner when faced with increased BLM situations or instances. Based on intensity and time frame of how these resources are deployed, a likely detrimental resultant outcome may arise to impact their social relationships in the workplace. In contrast, employees with low zero-sum beliefs and low BLMs are less likely to feel ostracized by their organization because being less hyper responsive and greater cognitive resource management (Callahan, 2007). Based on these arguments, the following is hypothesized:

Hypothesis 4. Zero-sum belief moderates the positive relationship between employee bottom-line mentality and ostracism, such that the relationship is stronger for employees with higher (versus lower) zero-sum beliefs.

As suggested in Hypothesis 3 and 4, it is predicted the mediated relationship to be conditionally affected via second-stage moderation.

Hypothesis 5. Zero-sum belief as a second-stage moderator of the positive indirect relationship between perceived organizational bottom-line mentality climate and ostracism via employee bottom-line mentality. This mediated relationship is stronger for employees with higher (versus lower) zero-sum beliefs.

3. Methods

3.1. Sample and procedure

Respondent data was collected over the course of five weeks (July 18th – August 22nd) using an online Qualtrics survey. Collection was

purposely paced with batch releases to review incoming data for quality control. This was also done to reduce time-of-day effects and help ensure greater sample diversity. Recruitment was specific to full-time working adults from the United States via Amazon's Mechanical Turk (MTurk). Research supports crowdsourcing respondents via MTurk to be a reliable source of data for generalization purposes (Buhrmester et al., 2011; Buhrmester et al., 2018; Weber & Bauman, 2019). According to Harmon et al. (2015), such sampling is acceptable for behavioral science and management research, per the focus of this study. In addition to best MTurk recruitment practices as recommended by Aguinis et al. (2021), the HIT approval rate was stipulated to be above 95 % for prospects. Respondents in this study were compensated \$0.75 in base pay and a \$0.35 bonus for correctly answering the two attention check items. A bonus was used to reduce attrition. The rate was based on a separate pilot sample ($N = 29$) used exclusively for instrument trial evaluation, which indicated an average time of 8.29 min ($SD = 2.28$). The prevailing federal minimum wage at the time of this study was \$7.25 per hour. MTurk study respondents were advised in the research recruitment posting and Qualtrics survey information sheet that tools would be utilized to detect their attentiveness in the study. Respondents were not told the survey entailed two specific attention check items. The attention check questions stated: “Please choose ‘neutral’ for this question” and “Please choose ‘strongly agree’ for this question.” Work by Greenbaum et al. (2022) similarly evidenced such questions to be appropriate for respondent attentiveness assessment. This purpose was twofold, detect careless responding and/or bot activity. To further reduce bot activity, the survey employed a “Captcha verification” immediately after the “Participant Information Sheet” in the online survey instrument.

A total of 263 individuals accessed the online survey. There were 11 omitted observations based on incompleteness and/or non-response. Of the 252 completed responses, 32 (14.45 %) respondents were removed because of missing one or both attention checks. Based on MTurk sampling research, as discussed by Aguinis et al. (2021), failed attention checks can be as high as 15 %, and attrition rates >30 %. As a percentage of missed attentiveness items, the percentages were within tolerance. After omitting all those who failed attention checks, a final usable sample of 220 observations resulted. The average age of respondents was 36.25 years ($SD = 10.69$); 52.7 % were women; 75.5 % White/Non-Hispanic, 10 % Asian, 4.5 % Hispanic/Latino, 3.2 % Black/African American, and 6.8 % other/not identified. The average organizational tenure was 13.03 years ($SD = 9.72$); 37 % identified as being a supervisor.

To identify an appropriate sample size, a priori power analysis was performed and based on eight predictors (substantive, interaction, and control variables) with a small-to-medium effect size ($f^2 = 0.08$) and power at 0.80, resulting in a suggested sample size of 196. Oversampling in the recruitment occurred to mitigate a loss of power (reduce Type 2 error) and to achieve the targeted effect size. This study had Institutional Review Board (IRB) oversight and approval because it involved human subjects. In addition, the respondents' informed consent was obtained. Beyond IRB oversight, best practices for research, ethics, compliance, and safety were adhered to in accordance with Collaborative Institutional Training Initiative (CITI Program) guidelines and recommendations.

3.2. Measures

Unless noted, respondents answered item statements in this study on a seven-point Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree* to 7 = *strongly agree*). The complete list of scale items is provided in Appendix A.

3.2.1. Perceived organizational climate bottom-line mentality (POCBLM)

Measuring perceptions of an organizational climate to be bottom-line mentality-based involved adapting Greenbaum et al.'s (2012) four-item scale. Specifically, an adaptation of the referent from “I” to “My organization” preceding the items in our survey. A sample item was, “My

organization treats the bottom line as more important than anything else.” ($\alpha = 0.96$).

3.2.2. Employee bottom-line mentality (EBLM)

Employee bottom-line mentality was measured with Greenbaum et al.'s (2012) four-item scale. A sample item was “I only care about business outcomes.” ($\alpha = 0.91$).

3.2.3. Zero-sum beliefs (ZSB)

Zero-sum beliefs was measured using six items created by Crocker and Canevello (2008). Example items include: “One person's success depends on another person's failure;” and “I believe that people are basically self-interested” ($\alpha = 0.84$).

3.2.4. Work ostracism (WO)

Work ostracism was measured using 10 items created by Ferris et al. (2008). Example items include: “Others avoided you at work;” and “Others at work shut you out of the conversation” ($\alpha = 0.97$).

3.2.5. Controls

Social desirability was measured using five items created by Crowne and Marlowe (1960) to control for potential response biases. Example items include: “I'm always willing to admit it when I make a mistake;” and “I never resent being asked to return a favor” ($\alpha = 0.79$). While this scale was originally developed and scored as a binary true or false measure, research has also adapted it with scaling (Huang et al., 2019). In addition, demographic variables of gender (0 = female, 1 = male) and age were used as controls, as well as organizational tenure. Similar to Babalola et al. (2021), multiple analyses were performed with and without controls. It was concluded the pattern of results did not meaningfully change nor was the significance of relationships reverted. According to Becker (2005), when controls do not present concerns for confounding as discussed, they are recommended to be removed. This being so, demographic variables and organizational tenure were removed but social desirability was retained for various analyses and final model parsimony.

3.3. Analytic approach

Statistical data analyses in this study used R (version 4.2.2). Hypotheses were tested using regression analysis and a method outlined by Preacher et al. (2007) using Hayes' (2022) PROCESS Macro (version 4.3.1) for R. The “lavaan” and “semPlot” libraries were used to perform the confirmatory factor analysis and various CMB techniques. To generate and visualize the interaction plot in this study, the “emmeans” and “ggplot2” libraries were used. Several analyses were performed with base R, e.g., cross-tabulations of demographics, Harman's One Factor Test, etc. G*Power was used to perform both a priori and post-hoc power analyses rather than R based on universal acceptance and consistency within the scholar research community.

4. Results

4.1. Preliminary analyses

Several preliminary analyses in this study were performed to evaluate the internal consistency, convergent and discriminant validity of the constructs. The composite reliability (CR) was >0.7 for each construct. This indicates the constructs to have internal consistency and reliability (Hair et al., 2010). The average variance extracted (AVE) for each construct was above 0.5, supporting convergent validity. A potential face validity concern was noted with an item in the zero-sum belief measure, in particular, Item #5. It had a weak loading (< 0.5), we removed it from the construct. For comparison purposes and assessment, all analyses in this study with the inclusion and exclusion of Item #5 were performed, and there were no meaningful or statistical

differences in the results. This being so, the reported findings exclude the item in question for concerns previously addressed.

An examination of discriminant validity among the study variables was performed with two assessments, the Fornell and Larcker (1981) criterion and the HTMT ratio of correlations (Hair et al., 2017; Henseler et al., 2015). The Fornell Larcker criterion compares each construct's square-rooted AVE and its correlation to other constructs. As shown in Table 1, the square-rooted AVE exceeds the correlation coefficients of comparative constructs, thus supporting distinctiveness. The HTMT ratio was performed because it has increased sensitivity for detecting discriminant validity, whereas the Fornell Larcker criterion has potential issues (Voorhees et al., 2016). Using the cutoff ratio of 0.85, all variables were below the threshold, thus affirming support for discriminant validity.

4.2. Common method bias

This study collected data from the same source, which can raise the issue of common method bias (CMB). Respondents were assured their responses would be confidential from a design procedure and handled in accordance with ethical standards of human subject research, as guided by the lead author's IRB. Conveying such things is effective for mitigating and reducing CMB (Podsakoff et al., 2003). In addition, within the question blocks of the survey, items were randomized, and different response scaling was used for factor items when possible. According to Bagozzi and Yi (2012), using a single method to evaluate and assess this potential concern for CMB is not sufficient. Several statistical approaches were employed as recommended by (Podsakoff et al., 2003), of which all techniques incorporated the social desirability construct as a control variable. First, the Harman One Factor Test (Podsakoff & Organ, 1986) was performed on the measurement variables. The total variance explained by the first factor was 39.72 %, thus below the 50 % threshold (Saris & Gallhofer, 2014) and a more stringent measure of 40 % (Babin et al., 2016). This supports a single factor did not emerge to explain most of the variance. The next technique carried out was an extraction of the variance from an unmeasured common latent factor (CLF). Variance resulted in a value of 38.44 %, thus below the threshold of 50 % (Williams & McGonagle, 2016). Thirdly, an unmeasured CLF approach was used to evaluate the item differences of standardized weights. This technique extracts the weightings from a structural model with and without the CLF and analyzes each item to be less than a recommended cut-off value of 0.20 (Gaudioso et al., 2017; Serrano Archimi et al., 2018). After calculating the differences between both models, the absolute weighting values ranged from 0.001 to 0.153, thus below the threshold. Considering the survey's design procedures and analytic techniques to assess the potential for sampling concern, it is concluded that CMB is not likely to be an issue.

4.3. Descriptive statistics

Means, standard deviations, and correlations for the study variables are in Table 2.

Table 1
Composite reliability, average variance extracted, correlations, and heterotrait-monotrait (HTMT) ratio of correlations.

Variable	CR	AVE	1	2	3	4
1. Perceived OCBLM	0.96	0.84	0.92	0.54	0.45	0.36
2. Employee BLM	0.92	0.73	0.50	0.85	0.57	0.44
3. Zero-sum belief	0.85	0.54	0.41	0.50	0.74	0.61
4. Work ostracism	0.97	0.77	0.36	0.41	0.55	0.88

Notes: CR = composite reliability, AVE = average variance extracted, square root of average variance extracted for the constructs are reported in the diagonal (in bold). Values below the diagonal line are correlation coefficients between variables. Values above the diagonal line are HTMT values.
Source: Authors' own work.

Table 2

Descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliabilities among study variables.

Variable	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Perceived OCBLM	4.04	1.76	(0.96)						
2. Employee BLM	3.20	1.43	0.50**	(0.91)					
3. Zero-sum belief	2.89	1.21	0.42**	0.52**	(0.84)				
4. Work ostracism	1.91	1.18	0.36**	0.41**	0.54**	(0.97)			
5. Social desirability	4.51	1.21	0.00	0.05	-0.12	-0.07	(0.79)		
6. Age	36.25	10.69	-0.10	-0.27**	-0.27**	-0.17*	0.07	—	
7. Gender	0.47	0.50	0.12	0.07	0.09*	0.05	0.05	-0.11	—
8. Tenure	13.03	9.72	-0.00	-0.22**	-0.18	-0.14*	-0.07	0.78*	-0.14*

Notes: $n = 220$. Gender was coded female = 0, male = 1. OCBLM = Organizational climate bottom-line mentality. Alpha reliabilities are reported in the diagonal.* $p < 0.05$ level.** $p < 0.01$.

Source: Authors' own work.

4.4. Confirmatory factor analyses

The factor structure of the measurement model was examined by performing a confirmatory factor analysis using maximum-likelihood estimation. Only the substantive variables were included in the measurement: perceived OCBLM, employee BLM, zero-sum beliefs, and work ostracism. The recommended criteria by Hu and Bentler (1999) was used to evaluate model fit factors and related items. Results of the four-factor model provided an adequate fit to the data ($\chi^2(224) = 593.94$, $p < 0.001$, CFI = 0.93; TLI = 0.92, RMSEA = 0.08; SRMR = 0.06). The results of the four-factor model exhibited better-fit indices than an alternative three-factor model that allowed zero-sum belief and employee BLM items to load onto the same factor (i.e., 3-factor A). This alternative three-factor model allowed perceived OCBLM and zero-sum belief to load on the same factor (i.e., 3-factor B), and an alternative three-factor model (i.e., 3-factor C) that allowed perceived OCBLM and employee BLM to load onto the same factor. Please see Table 3.

4.5. Hypotheses testing

Hypothesis 1 predicted that an organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality is positively related to an employee bottom-line mentality. Results for Model 1 in Table 4 indicate a positive relationship between the organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality and employee bottom-line mentality ($b = 0.41$, $p < 0.01$). Thus, **Hypothesis 1** is supported.

Hypothesis 2 predicted that an employee's bottom-line mentality is positively related to ostracism. Results for Model 2 in Table 4 indicate a positive relationship between an employee bottom-line mentality and ostracism ($b = 0.26$, $p < 0.01$). Thus, **Hypothesis 2** is supported.

Hypothesis 3 predicted that an organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality has a positive indirect effect on work ostracism via increased employee bottom-line mentality. Results from the bias-corrected bootstrap test support a positive indirect effect of perceived organizational BLM climate on work ostracism via increased employee BLM (indirect effect = 0.108, 95 % CI [0.052, 0.177]). This effect was examined with an alternative estimation by using the Monte Carlo

method (20,000 draws). The results were similar (indirect effect = 0.108, 95 % CI [0.058, 0.164], thus strengthening the robustness of our findings. Performing the Monte Carlo estimation severed the purpose Type 1 error protection (Hayes & Scharkow, 2013). Therefore, considering both biased corrected bootstrapping and Monte Carlo, **Hypothesis 3** is supported.

Hypothesis 4 predicted the relationship between employee bottom-line mentality and work ostracism to have moderation by zero-sum belief. Results for Model 3 in Table 4 indicate the employee BLM x ZSB interaction term is significant for work ostracism ($b = 0.13$, $p < 0.01$). A simple slopes analysis was performed, and the resulting interaction plot is illustrated in Fig. 2. This plot shows the effect of employee BLM on work ostracism is insignificant at a lower level of ZSB ($b = -0.02$, $n.s.$), and the effect becomes significant and positive when ZSB is higher ($b = 0.29$, $p < 0.01$). The difference in the strength of these effects is significant ($\Delta b = 0.315$, $p < 0.01$).

Hypothesis 5 predicted the positive indirect effect of an organizational climate perceived as bottom-line mentality, on work ostracism, via employee bottom-line mentality is stronger for individuals with high zero-sum beliefs than for those with low zero-sum beliefs. The results (see Table 4) suggest that the indirect effect of an organizational climate perceived as bottom-line mentality on work ostracism through employee bottom-line mentality is stronger when zero-sum belief is higher (estimate = 0.109, 95 % CI [0.035, 0.195]) than when it is lower (estimate = -0.019, 95 % CI [-0.081, 0.040]). The difference in the strength of these effects is significant ($\Delta = 0.129$, $p < 0.01$). **Hypothesis 5** is further supported based on the index of moderated-mediation, not including zero ($b = 0.052$, SE = 0.02, 95 % CI [0.013, 0.091]).

5. Discussion and implications

5.1. Discussion

An organizational focus on broader economic success as compared to other success indicators is not uncommon, as the long-term viability of an organization is dependent on its financial well-being (Carroll, 1991). A focus on the bottom line can create competition among employees.

Table 3

Results of confirmatory factor analyses.

Model	χ^2	df	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf	CFI	TLI	RMSEA	SRMR
4-factor model	593.94**	224	—	—	0.93	0.92	0.08	0.06
3-factor model A (combines ZSB and EBLM)	904.13**	227	310.19**	3	0.87	0.85	0.12	0.10
3-factor model B (combines Perceived OCBLM and ZSB)	1010.79**	227	416.85**	3	0.85	0.83	0.13	0.15
3-factor model C (combines Perceived OCBLM and EBLM)	1107.76**	227	513.82**	3	0.83	0.81	0.13	0.12
1-factor	2355.43**	230	1761.49**	7	0.59	0.54	0.20	0.17

Notes: $n = 220$. OCBLM = Organizational climate bottom-line mentality; EBLM = Employee bottom-line mentality; ZSB = Zero-sum belief. CFI is the comparative fit index; TLI is the Tucker-Lewis index; RMSEA is the root-mean-square error of approximation; SRMR is the standardized root mean squared residual. ** $p < .01$.

Source: Authors' own work.

Table 4

Results from the estimated moderated mediation model.

Model 1	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	<i>R</i> ²
Mediator variable model: employee BLM					0.26
Constant	1.28	0.38	3.42	0.001	
Perceived organizational climate BLM	0.41	0.05	8.63	0.000	
Social desirability	0.06	0.07	0.79	0.429	
Model 2					
Dependent variable model: work ostracism					0.21
Constant	0.91	0.33	2.76	0.006	
Perceived organizational climate BLM	0.13	0.05	2.76	0.006	
Employee BLM	0.26	0.06	4.54	0.000	
Social desirability	−0.08	0.07	−1.36	0.175	
Model 3					
Dependent variable model: work ostracism					0.36
Constant	1.62	0.31	5.29	0.000	
Perceived organizational climate BLM	0.10	0.04	2.32	0.021	
Employee BLM	0.11	0.06	1.91	0.057	
ZSB	0.30	0.07	4.39	0.000	
Employee BLM x ZSB	0.13	0.04	3.50	0.001	
Social desirability	−0.06	0.06	−1.01	0.313	
Conditional indirect effects					
Effect	<i>SE</i>	BOOT LLCI		BOOT ULCI	
−1 SD below mean of ZSB (−1.24)	−0.019	0.03	−0.081	0.040	
Mean of ZSB	0.045	0.03	−0.004	0.099	
+1 SD above mean of ZSB (+1.24)	0.109	0.04	0.035	0.195	
Index of moderated mediation	0.052	0.02	0.013	0.091	

Notes: *n* = 220. Unstandardized regression estimates are reported. Employee BLM and Zero-sum beliefs were mean centered prior to analysis. LLCI = lower limit confidence interval, ULCI = upper limit confidence interval. Confidence intervals were formed using 10,000 bootstrapped samples. BLM = bottom-line mentality. ZSB = zero-sum belief.

Source: Authors' own work.

Plausibly, an explanation is some employees experience a specific social axiom activation in response. In particular, we feel one characterized as seeing one person's success as another person's loss, i.e., a zero-sum belief (Greenbaum et al., 2012). Extant literature has generally treated a bottom-line mentality and zero-sum beliefs as synonymous. However, the results of this study provide evidence that individual-level beliefs might be a bigger driver of negative outcomes, in this case ostracism, than having a bottom-line mentality. Furthermore, this study corroborates work by Keeler et al. (in press), which argued both factors represent related but different constructs. This study draws on Social Cognitive Theory (SCT), which suggests that individuals adapt their behaviors and mindsets based on their environmental context and the observed behaviors of those around them (Bandura, 1986; Cherian & Jacob, 2013).

As expected, this study found a positive relationship between an organizational climate perceived as a bottom-line mentality (POCBLM) and an employee bottom-line mentality (BLM). In addition, Babalola et al. (2020) and Hanu et al. (2024) evidence support that employees are influenced by their organization's or supervisors' emphasis on financial outcomes, leading them to adopt similar bottom-line oriented mindsets. Farasat et al. (2021) and Chen et al. (2022) further confirm that such climates foster employee BLM by reinforcing a focus on immediate financial results and competitive behaviors. Importantly, this finding is a reminder of the influence of organizational climates and environments on people's work values and priority alignment. Employees are prone to mirroring ways of thinking they are around at an organization,

especially BLM-based.

When employees have increased BLMs, they may be at risk for workplace ostracism. An explanation of this relationship stems from an individual tendency of over fixation on organizational outcomes, leading to misaligned priorities. This process is likely to increase workplace isolation (perceived or actual) because other outcomes are susceptible to mismanagement. This is especially true for social relationships because of self-interest cognitions that BLM promotes via mental preoccupation (Babalola et al., 2020). In addition, Liu et al. (2022) highlight that a strong BLM can lead to psychological contract breaches and feelings of undervaluation, which align with ostracism. Quade et al. (2022) and Greenbaum et al. (2012) provide additional support by showing that a focus on financial outcomes and individual success can foster environments where ostracism becomes more prevalent, as employees with strong BLMs might alienate themselves from their peers. Thus, this is why Greenbaum et al. (2012) describe BLM as "tunnel vision." In other words, an excessive focus on financial outcomes or organizational initiatives at the expense of workplace social relationships should not be surprising when an employee feels ostracized. This finding is consistent with SCT, which posits that individuals will model behaviors they observe, including those leading to exclusion or ostracism (Bandura, 1986). To our point, the relationship and risk are credible when thinking about an unbalanced fixation on potentially misaligned priorities to disrupt a social component in the workplace.

This study proposes an indirect effect of an organization's BLM climate on employees feeling ostracized. Both the bias-corrected bootstrap and Monte Carlo techniques evidence robust support for our theorized relationship concerning Hypothesis 3. This corroborates a psychological process in the employee from an organizational climate, increasing the likelihood of feeling excluded. According to the SCT framework, a triadic reciprocal determinism takes place. The environment (organizational climate) influences an employee's personal cognitive change via adopting learned BLMs. An internalization process occurs when an individual integrates said changes from organizational initiatives. A behavioral element of interpersonal friction is the resultant, which stems from cognitive change and learning. Arguably, the interplay of these psychological dynamics can increase the propensity for an employee to feel excluded at work. Explanations that reason this intersection relates to individual conformity/compliance and self-interest. We are not saying these are mutually exclusive; thus, there may be an overlap. SCT already substantiates learning and observing; however, to a deeper extent, adopting BLM cognitively may also be out of conformity and compliance to fit with a group (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004). In other words, external pressures (social, emotional, etc.) may drive changes in a person's behavior or cognition. Considering the climate and employee BLM dynamic of this study, Kouchaki et al. (2013) found that management-derived BLM activates an employee's self-interest cognitions. These avenues suggest a decision assessment (Mitchell et al., 2018) and a cost-benefit analysis (Wolfe, 1988) occur psychologically. This is so because the employee tries to maximize their needs in response to the BLM (Greenbaum et al., 2018; Savani et al., 2016). Furthermore, they will likely take on a transactional way of thinking concerning self-interest (Babalola et al., 2020). Being transactional with a focus on self-interest will reshape how an employee engages with coworkers. Such thinking could be intentional or unintentional but comes at the expense of social interactions. The reasoning for this position is that individuals have an increased tendency to exhibit behaviors that violate norms or ethical conduct in carrying out BLM objectives (Mitchell et al., 2018; Nagin et al., 2002). Such individuals tend to be unethical (Kouchaki et al., 2013) and forgo morality (Gino & Mogilner, 2014) when factoring in self-interest. All of this matters because when self-interest is part of the equation, some of these characteristics we described about an individual are likely to surface, thus causing coworkers to distance themselves from such a person (i.e., less trustworthy, cooperative, or socially desirable). Arguably, even a reluctance to accept or endorse a BLM by an employee is likely to alter

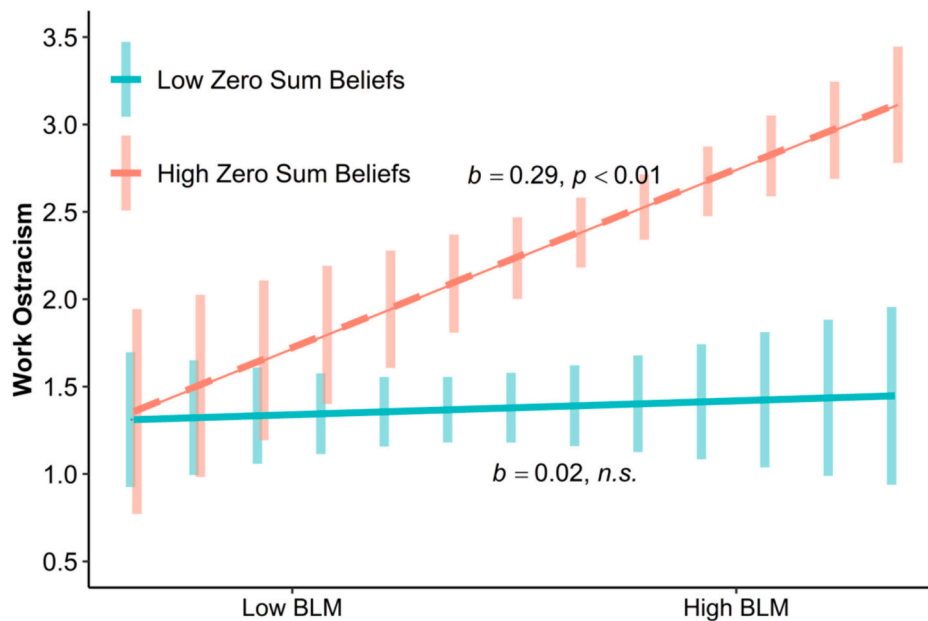


Fig. 2. Interaction of zero-sum belief and employee BLM predicting feeling ostracized^a.

^aBLM = bottom-line mentality.

Source: Authors' own work.

their outward behavior. Again, based on a gradually be predisposed to self-interest cognitions, they are likely to violate relationship expectations with coworkers. Resultant outcomes to explain peer exclusion may involve diminished trust, perceived social threats, or potentially dissociation. While work by Babalola et al. (2020) and Liu et al. (2022) highlighted significant research that evidenced supervisory-based BLM to lead to problematic outcomes via employee internalization, exploring exclusion has yet to be performed. This being so, support for Hypothesis 3 bolsters the theoretical mediation path (Bandura, 1986; Cherian & Jacob, 2013) and also advances work on problematic employee internalization outcomes. In simple terms, when employees perceive or experience their organizational environment as emphasizing a bottom-line mentality, they are likely to adopt a similar way of priority thinking, which can be at the expense of work relationships.

Of particular interest in this research is the interplay of the ZSB social axiom (personal factor of SCT) to influence values and priorities by the employee relative to feeling excluded at work. Our findings verified ZSB to be a significant moderator of the relationship. Importantly, the direct path between ostracism and BLM increased in significance strength from lower to higher levels of ZSB, as revealed by simple slopes analysis. Interestingly, feelings of workplace ostracism are only exacerbated by the condition of an elevation in both BLM and ZSB. In situations where employees do not possess high levels of zero-sum beliefs, their perceptions of BLM did not significantly affect their perceptions of ostracism. This finding matters for establishing employee BLM as a condition related to feelings of ostracism in the workplace, especially since it would not otherwise be teased out in Hypothesis 2. In situations with a high level of BLM, employees may assume that the success of one individual is not mutually exclusive to that of another (e.g., the “I can win, and you can win” mentality). In this scenario, employees do not perceive the same degree of perceived ostracism. Such discovery is corroborated by SCT and related research, which suggest that individuals who hold high zero-sum beliefs and perceive resources as scarce and competitive are more susceptible to contributing to and experiencing ostracism (Andrews-Fearon & Davidai, 2023; Crocker & Canevello, 2008). Beyond exclusion that may result from a high ZSB individual, a collective of like-mindedness could lead to a more competitive environment, thus fueling the climate to become hypercompetitive. Essentially, things we have already discussed about distrust and self-interest become more

prevalent, driving a recursive cycle of focusing on gains at the expense of others. Based on the nature of ZSB to be described as a social axiom (i.e., generalized belief system to impact social relationships), the finding from Hypothesis 4 explains why two different people in the same organizational climate (characterized as high BLM) may have different interpretations and/or feelings of workplace ostracism.

An important research interest of this study concerned the indirect effect of POCBLM on ostracism through employee BLM, conditional on ZSB. In other words, is the conditional effect more prominent for individuals with higher zero-sum beliefs than those with lower zero-sum beliefs? The moderated-mediation index supports the significance of this path. This result validates the idea that zero-sum beliefs exacerbate the mediated relationship between POCBLM and ostracism, which is consistent with SCT's perspective on the way that competitive mindsets and ZSB beliefs can aggravate feelings of exclusion and ostracism (Crocker & Canevello, 2015; Różycka-Tran et al., 2015). Again, theoretically, the relationship of our study variables is supported by SCT based on learned behavior/cognitions via observation, modeling, reinforcement, and internalization from environmental (climate) and personal factors (e.g., ZSB, employee BLM) (see Bandura, 1985; Bandura, 2001; Yue et al., 2023). The insight of affirming Hypothesis 5 relationship is that when organizations emphasize outcomes to the extent of “being the most important” or “above everything else,” certain employees may be triggered based on their specific ZSB beliefs. For some, it could lead to an undesirable social outcome for the employee. This position is because high ZSB employees may interpret competitive environments as threatening rather than motivating. Such individuals are more prone to over-fixate and find themselves with tunnel vision focused on specific priorities rather than having balance. Essentially, the employee could find themselves either in a survival mode or in a race to be recognized as the best performer for recognition and self-interest (Babalola et al., 2020). This being so, a situation arises where workplace exclusion is felt as a perception rather than actual because of how BLM is associated with a misguided mindset. Alternatively, a high ZSB employee may experience ostracism at work due to co-workers finding it challenging to work with them due to a heightened self-interest cognitive state (arising from ZSB). In other words, the manifestation of increased ZSB with increased prioritization focus from BLM is likely to fracture human relations as coworkers may describe the individual as

“abrasive,” “all about themselves,” “not genuine,” or “not a team player.” Our results with [Hypothesis 5](#) extend beyond [Hypothesis 4](#) to evidence a significant conditional indirect path relationship. Importantly, we are not saying all ZSB is bad. On the contrary, individuals need to be self-aware of their ZSB predisposition to view situations. Stated differently, moderation and avoidance of excessiveness are important for social relationship management in the workplace. Our research suggests that individuals will be at increased risk of feeling excluded if not taken seriously. This position is further affirmed and concluded by [Davidai \(2025\)](#), specific to ZSB.

5.2. Theoretical implications

A contribution to BLM is made by applying SCT as the foundation to understand how a climate of BLM influences employee BLM and perceptions/feelings of workplace ostracism. SCT can help with reasoning and explaining different dynamics within business environments and how they shape employees' attitudes towards a mindset rooted in the bottom line. Under SCT, four sources of influence impact how people learn from their own and others' experiences: personal factors, behavioral factors, environmental factors, and cognitive factors ([Greenbaum et al., 2012](#)). Furthermore, individuals consistently regulate their behavior by comparing their standard of conduct with environmental circumstances, especially organizational climates ([Bandura, 1986](#); [Domino et al., 2015](#)). Consistent with SCT, we found a further contributing factor that helps explain the impact of BLM on adverse outcomes, namely a social axiom entailing zero-sum beliefs. ZSB can be viewed as a separate personal factor (compared to individual BLM) within SCT. Our theorized work adds contributions to the field of cognitive psychology and social relationships in the workplace. First, it advances a call by [Greenbaum et al. \(2023\)](#) to study BLM in different contexts; thus, we did so via climate perception. Second, [Howard et al. \(2020\)](#) laid the groundwork with their meta-analysis to study antecedents and outcomes of workplace ostracism. Thus, we addressed their call. Thirdly, [Keeler et al. \(in press\)](#) called for further testing their 2×2 experimental work beyond a student sample. We did so with workers and a more complex model. Beyond these added contributions, we make compelling arguments drawn from SCT while discussing how compliance/conformity and self-interest literature may be integrated with a cognitive process adjustment.

5.3. Practical implications

Managerially, BLM climates, regardless of being present within a team, division, or business unit can present exclusionary challenges for individuals. Such position is more pronounced when factoring in the strength of ZSB. It is well documented that BLMs as a form of a competitive climate may exacerbate selfishness, leading to workplace ostracism and strained social dynamics ([Greenbaum et al., 2021](#)). Practically, this emphasizes the need for organizations to monitor how employees interpret performance-driven values. Leadership should cultivate a culture that values cooperation, shared success, and relational transparency. Employees who internalize BLM through the lens of ZSB may view workplace success as a win-lose proposition, making them vulnerable to feeling excluded or acting in isolating ways. Promoting a ‘positive-sum’ belief that frames success as mutually attainable can buffer such effects (see [Knack, 2005](#)). Thus, HR professionals and organizational leaders need to play a key role in employees to not having grudges or keeping score among team members. It is important that they discourage interpersonal resentment in the work environment. Having an awareness and being active like so can curtail tribalism and lead to allyship. Importantly, work by [Stefaniak et al. \(2020\)](#) found positive-sum beliefs to be associated with more constructive and prosocial forms of collective action for advantaged group members. A resultant outcome was that equity among individuals was promoted along with allyship. Research like this reinforces cultural norms, mitigating

interpersonal fallout, and redirecting competition towards collective achievement is very much possible.

Organizations can reduce the negative consequences of BLM climates by restructuring systems that reward only individual outcomes. One way to do this is with positive goal interdependence between team members. According to [Deutsch \(2006\)](#) interdependent goals should lead people to believe gains by another person or group do result in a disadvantage others. Strategies include designing performance evaluations that emphasize team-based goals, peer collaboration, and inclusive leadership behaviors. Shifting from a ‘winner-takes-all’ structure to one that rewards shared impact may prevent the emergence of narcissistic competitiveness or social undermining, both of which are associated with high BLM and ZSB. In addition, job design/crafting interventions, such as cross-functional teamwork, mentorship programs, and co-led projects, can foster a sense of community, and build relational trust ([Grant & Parker, 2009](#)). The literature has well documented such interventions to reduce the likelihood of employee ostracism. One reason is mindsets shift from competitive to collaborative. Work by [Grant and Parker \(2009\)](#) also suggest things like leadership development programs that focus on psychological safety and early identification of interpersonal strain are critical in reshaping the narrative around success. Arguably, these organizational practices not only minimize the isolating effects of the BLM-ZSB interplay but also improve morale, creativity, and long-term productivity. An explanation is employees are likely to feel recognized, included, and aligned with broader mission-driven goals.

Lastly, special attention should make note of employees exhibiting characteristics of being elevated in both BLM and ZSB. If identified early enough, they may benefit from targeted interventions (e.g., executive coaching, reflective leadership training, or inclusion workshops) to reverse course. A recommended aim of any of these interventions should entail recalibrating employee self-perceptions and relational engagement. In addition, it is suggested that organizational leadership avoid framing performance purely in financial terms. Instead, holistic success seminars/trainings could be explored with a focus soft skill development – emotional intelligence, collaboration, or community-building. The seminars could be internal or external. By helping individuals shift away from zero-sum thinking to recognize the value of interdependence, employers can enhance relational cohesion and decrease perceived threats. Other recommendations may include encouraging regular feedback and peer learning sessions. Ultimately, there needs to be a balance of financial goals while incorporating inclusive practices. If done strategically, organizations should be enabled to harness the benefits of employee ambition without sacrificing workplace harmony or psychological well-being.

5.4. Limitations and future research

As with most studies, this study has both strengths and limitations. One limitation is using Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk) as a data collection platform. While MTurk samples are widely used in organizational research and provide diverse respondent pools, they may not fully represent organizational settings where hierarchical dynamics, in-person interactions, and workplace culture influence behavior. Additionally, MTurk respondents may vary in motivation or attentiveness, potentially affecting data reliability. We followed appropriate research guidelines in the recruitment of this crowdsourcing sampling. Methodologically, the instrument was designed to identify inattentiveness and remove respondents suspected of inattentiveness. A post-hoc analysis ([Bliese & Wang, 2020](#)) using the G*Power software ([Faul et al., 2009](#)) was performed to assess power and confidence in study results. Based on a sample size of 220 and the five predictors from Model 3 (see [Table 4](#)), the achieved statistical power was 0.91 for an effect size of 0.08, which exceeds the 0.80 threshold ([Cohen, 1992](#)). A second limitation is the potential issue of common method bias. The use of self-reports can inflate the relationships among the study variables. Although this is considered one of the concerns of self-report measures, it was imperative

to use self-reports to collect this data as there was interest in respondent's belief systems. An evaluation for CMB occurred using three different techniques. The results did not suggest a concern. Third, the nature of this data collection was cross-sectional. Patterns of relationships were uncovered that suggest causality; however, as a limitation, this cannot be implied. The results of this study corroborated the experimental findings by Keeler et al. (in press), which manipulated individual BLM and ZSB in their study of exclusion. Their work established the pretext for causality.

A fourth limitation is how psychological climate perceptions of BLM were measured. Climate data was collected at the individual level, not the group or organizational. This being so, Babalola et al. (2020) used a similar technique to measure perceived "top management" BLM without collecting dyads. Glick (1985) indicates many distinct levels of climate (individual, subunit/subsystem, and managerial). A psychological climate is an "individual's perception of their work environment" (Benzer & Horner, 2015, p. 457) or "how employees evaluate and interpret meaning from their work environments" (Patterson et al., 2005, p. 380). Aggregating individuals' psychological climate perceptions can form a more objective organizational-level climate measure. Future research on BLM could benefit from a nested study in which organizational climate can be assessed (see work by Resick et al., 2023). In doing so, recommendations by Bliese (2000) should be followed to justify aggregation. First, the groups should naturally occur, and a department or business unit could suffice. Second, within-group homogeneity should be present. Third, between-group heterogeneity should be identified. See work by Bliese (2000) and Mayer et al. (2010) for group size recommendations.

Future research should consider complementing the findings of this study with organizational field data or longitudinal designs that allow for nested samples within real workplace units. Another opportunity from this study concerns the perpetrator/target for ostracism. Previous research has indicated differences in the construct. Specifically, supervisor ostracism and coworker ostracism are separate types of workplace ostracism (Jahanzeb et al., 2018). A deeper examination of the disparate impact of BLM and zero-sum beliefs on these two types of ostracism could lead to a more thorough understanding of the nature of workplace ostracism. Lastly, an expansion of asymmetric zero-sum beliefs could be explored. Roberts and Davidai (2022) found evidence of asymmetrical zero-sum beliefs. Specifically, one might believe that others gain at one's own expense but not vice versa. This outcome is moderated by how threatened people feel by others' success and by the fact that reassuring people about their party's strengths eliminates asymmetric zero-sum beliefs.

6. Conclusion

Work climates shed light on an organization's shared policies, practices, and procedures, which may be formal and informal (Ostroff et al., 2003; Schneider, 1975). In situations where a climate has attributes of being elevated as BLM-based, there is a connection for employees to feel excluded via workplace ostracism. The strength of employee feelings becomes even more pronounced based on the strength of their ZSB. The central research objective was met to examine an interplay of psychological processes within an environment and individual. Results reinforce the potential for competitive climates to manifest organizational outcomes that can lead to reduced workplace morale and alienation. This interpretation may seem counterintuitive; however, the work and support provided in this paper provide a strong explanation. Importantly, employees with a cooperative mindset and who believe in mutual gain are less likely to be impacted by work climates characterized as BLM. Importantly, organizational change typically starts within an organization's climate (e.g., "how things work around here"). This research evidences the influence and potential outcome of a BLM climate. The literature supports several work climates (service, safety, diversity, innovation, etc.) that may coexist at a given time (Kuenzi &

Schminke, 2009; Schneider et al., 2002; Schneider et al., 2013). The choice to focus solely on BLM is due to it being most plausible for advancing research on exclusion in the workplace.

The present study offers insights into processes between individual belief systems and organizational climates that influence employee experiences. It draws attention to the necessity for organizations to rethink how their priority initiatives permeate within individuals and how such things get internalized or activate strong belief systems. It is agreed that businesses need to be profitable and remain competitive; we do not disagree. Therefore, it is advisable to establish supportive and collaborative policies and practices to achieve key performance indicators in the pursuit of victory and success!

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Justin B. Keeler: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Meagan E. Brock-Baskin:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Victoria McKee:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Sesan Adeniji:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Investigation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A

Scale items

Perceived Organizational Climate BLM ($\alpha = 0.96$) (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) (adapted from Greenbaum et al., 2012)

1. My organization treats the bottom line as more important than anything else.
2. My organization is solely concerned with meeting the bottom line.
3. My organization only cares about business outcomes.
4. My organization only cares about the business.

Employee BLM ($\alpha = 0.91$) (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) (Greenbaum et al., 2012)

1. I treat the bottom line as more important than anything else.
2. I am solely concerned with meeting the bottom line.
3. I only care about business outcomes.
4. I only care about the business.

Zero-sum Belief ($\alpha = 0.84$) (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) (Crocker & Canevello, 2008)

1. One person's success depends on another person's failure.
2. To succeed in this world, it is sometimes necessary to step on others along the way.
3. My success doesn't mean much if most other people succeed at the same task.

4. An accomplishment is only really meaningful if it is rare.
5. To give to others usually requires sacrifice on the part of the giver.
6. I believe that people are basically self-interested.

Work Ostracism ($\alpha = 0.97$) (1 = never, 7 = always) (Ferris et al., 2008)

1. Others ignore you at work.
2. Others leave the area when you enter.
3. Your greetings have gone unanswered at work.
4. You involuntarily sit alone in a crowded lunchroom at work.
5. Others avoid you at work.
6. You notice others do not look at you at work.
7. Others at work shut you out of the conversation.
8. Others refuse to talk to you at work.
9. Others at work treat you as if you weren't there.
10. Others at work do not invite you or ask you if you want anything when they take work breaks.

Social Desirability ($\alpha = 0.79$) (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree) (Crowne & Marlowe, 1960)

1. I'm always willing to admit it when I make a mistake.
2. I always practice what I preach.
3. I never resent being asked to return a favor.
4. I have never been irked when people expressed ideas very different from my own.
5. I have never deliberately said something to hurt someone's feelings.

Source: Authors' own work.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of this study is available upon request from the lead author on reasonable request.

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